

Diagnosis, Intractability, Risk, Efficacy (DIRE) Score^[A](1)(2)

Assess and rate each of the 4 criteria of the DIRE tool. Each criterion is rated on a scale of 1 to 3. Add up the scores for all 4 criteria. This is the total DIRE score for the patient at that time.

***Diagnosis** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Benign chronic condition with minimal objective findings or no definite medical diagnosis, eg, fibromyalgia, migraine headaches, nonspecific back pain (+1)
- ☐ Slowly progressive condition with moderate pain, or fixed condition with moderate objective findings, eg, failed back surgery syndrome, back pain with moderate degenerative changes, neuropathic pain (+2)
- ☐ Advanced condition with severe pain with objective findings, eg, severe ischemic vascular disease, advanced neuropathy, severe spinal stenosis (+3)

***Intractability** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Few therapies have been tried and the patient takes a passive role in the pain management process. (+1)
- ☐ Most customary treatments have been tried but the patient is not fully engaged in the pain management process, or barriers (eg, insurance, transportation, medical illness) prevent engagement. (+2)
- ☐ The patient is fully engaged in a spectrum of appropriate treatments but has had inadequate response. (+3)

***Risk** - (Risk = Total of Psychological + Chemical health + Reliability + Social support)

***Psychological** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Serious personality dysfunction or mental illness interfering with care, eg, personality disorder, severe affective disorder, significant personality issues (+1)
- ☐ Personality dysfunction or mental health illness interfering moderately with care, eg, depression, anxiety disorder (+2)
- ☐ Good communication with clinic, no significant personality dysfunction or mental illness (+3)

***Chemical health** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Active or very recent use of illicit drugs, excessive alcohol use, or prescription drug abuse (+1)
- ☐ Chemical dependence (eg, uses medications to cope with stress) or history of chemical dependency in remission (+2)
- ☐ No chemical dependency history, not drug-focused or chemically reliant (+3)

***Reliability** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ History of numerous problems, eg, medication misuse, missed appointments, poor follow-through (+1)
- ☐ Occasional difficulties with compliance, but generally reliable (+2)
- ☐ Highly reliable patient, eg, with medication adherence, appointments, treatments (+3)

***Social support** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Life in chaos, little family support and few close relationships, loss of most normal life roles (+1)
- ☐ Some impaired relationships and life roles (+2)
- ☐ Supportive family/close relationships, involved in work or school, no social isolation (+3)

***Efficacy** - Rate on scale 1 to 3.

- ☐ Poor function or minimal pain relief despite moderate to high doses (+1)
- ☐ Moderate benefit with function improved in a number of ways; or insufficient patient information, eg, patient has not tried opioids, has had very low doses or only a short trial on opioids (+2)
- ☐ Good improvement in pain, function, and quality of life with stable opioid doses over time (+3)

Score: 14

Scale for scoring

Score of 7 to 13: Not a suitable candidate for long-term opioid analgesia

Score of 14 to 21: May be a candidate for long-term opioid analgesia